PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS
School District No. 1J, Multnomah County
Board of Education

September 1, 2026
Intergovernmental Affairs Committee Meeting

Informal Meeting Minutes

In accordance with ORS 192.650, the District's official School Board Meeting Minutes are maintained via video recording and may be viewed at: https://www.youtube.com/@ppsboardofeducation

Pursuant to notice made by posting to the Board's public notices webpage and emailed to persons on the mailing list, a Portland Public Schools Board of Education Intergovernmental Affairs Committee meeting was held virtually and streamed live at: https://www.youtube.com/@ppsboardofeducation/live

Attendees

Committee Members: Christy Splitt (Committee Chair); Patte Sullivan; Stephanie Engelsman
Other attendees: Michelle Morrison - Chief Financial Officer; Ben Gurewitz - Senior Manager, Government Relations; Deborah Kafoury - Chief of Staff; Rosanne Powell - Senior Manager, Board Operations.

Call to Order / Introductions

Committee Chair Splitt called the meeting to order at 12:02 pm.

Public Comments

There was no public comment.

Committee Purpose and Overview of the Year Ahead

Staff provided an overview of the purpose and planned work of the committee in preparation for the 2027 legislative session. The committee will work toward developing legislative priorities for Board consideration, hear from external partners about their legislative priorities, and provide opportunities for Board members to receive legislative updates and discuss advocacy strategies. There was a discussion on the timeline to develop a legislative agenda for Board adoption before the start of the long session.

Public Employee Retirement System (PERS) Update and Overview

Chief Financial Officer Michelle Morrison provided an overview of the Public Employee Retirement System (PERS). She shared the financial impact of upcoming changes to the PERS employer rate, with the greatest impact expected in 2027–28. More information is coming in October.

Committee members asked questions about pension obligation bonds, side accounts, employee eligibility and vesting, and the potential for future strategies to address PERS costs. Chief Morrison noted that staff is exploring options and expects to bring additional information to the Board. The committee agreed that PERS is a complex topic that warrants continued discussion.

Review and Discussion of Legislative Principles

Staff presented proposed legislative principles to help guide the development of the Board's 2027 legislative priorities and support Board members in conversations with legislators. The proposed principles included adequate funding to meet student needs, support for students with disabilities, strengthening educator preparation programs and ending unfunded mandates. Committee members also expressed the importance of raising the issue of the financial impact of PERS to school districts.

Committee members requested a list of unfunded mandates, including information about associated costs and other impacts on the District. Staff noted that the Coalition of School Administrators and Oregon School Boards Association have an updated list that includes some cost information.

The committee discussed the role of external partners in developing the legislative priorities. Organizations invited to upcoming meetings include the Portland Association of Teachers, Community and Parents for Public Schools. Committee members were invited to suggest additional organizations.

Future Topics / Next Steps

Committee members expressed interest in additional guidance on effective legislative advocacy and how Board members and community members can engage with legislators. The committee will continue its discussion of the legislative principles at the next meeting and consider a recommendation to the Board. The committee also plans to continue the PERS discussion, including an opportunity for Chief Morrison to return for follow-up questions.

Adjourn

Committee Chair Splitt adjourned the meeting at 1:00 pm.

Submitted by:
Rosanne Powell
Senior Board Manager / Board Clerk
Portland Public Schools